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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Casten looks to gain rural support

Democratic US rep hopes to win over voters in Republican southern Illinois

By Rick Pearson and Jeremy Gornier
Chicago Tribune

CARTERVILLE, Ill. — Southwest suburban Democratic U.S. Rep. Sean Casten acknowledged he wasn't sure what to expect when he accepted an invitation by the state's Democratic county chairs to host a town hall Sunday in the ruby red southern Illinois home of the state's most Republican congressional district.

In addition to speaking more than 300 miles from his Downers Grove home, the four-term lawmaker's trip to six-term Republican Rep. Mike Bost's 12th Congressional District also meant traversing the sharp cultural divide between a growing upstate Democratic suburban base and the rural religious fundamentalist conservatism that predominates within the 34-county district that makes up the southern third of Illinois.

Casten's trip, along with a visit a day earlier to Dixon, the boyhood home of the late President Ronald Reagan in the 16th Congressional District of GOP Rep. Darin LaHood, is in line with national Democratic efforts to host "town halls" in Republican districts. Democrats are using them as a rallying point over the chaotic early months of Donald Trump's second presidency.

It's also poking at the advice that the head of the GOP's congressional campaign committee, North Carolina Rep. Richard Hudson, gave to his Republican colleagues that they stop holding in-person town hall meetings because of anti-Trump protesters.

But unlike higher-profile events featuring Sen. Bernie Sanders of Vermont and New York Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, Casten's southern Illinois appearance was in rock-solid GOP territory, where Trump won 71% of the vote in November and where 70.5% of the district's voters backed Trump in 2020.

"When I see my Republican colleagues on the other side of the aisle ducking all of these events and saying one thing out of one side of their mouth and then voting the other way and then not having the courage to stand up, I sort of feel like, if you love democracy and if you stand up, your job is to make sure the voters are informed," Casten said.

"I'm not going to run against Mike Bost," he said of the GOP

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INSIDE

Review: Mamet's 'Henry Johnson'

Playwright David Mamet's fascinating 2023 work, now in its Chicago premiere at the reopened Biograph Theatre, makes the defining theme of his plays as raw and explicit as anything he's previously written. **Arts & Living**

McIlroy finally wins the Masters

Rory McIlroy turned another major collapse into his grandest moment of all in a sudden-death playoff Sunday to win the Masters and take his place in golf history as the sixth player to claim the career Grand Slam. **Chicago Sports**



Nuclear power is generated at the Dresden Generating Station in Morris, Illinois, on Thursday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Momentum building for nuclear power in Illinois

Legislators consider allowing larger reactors as they try to satisfy both rising demand for power and Pritzker's clean energy goals

By Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — As Illinois closes in on its deadline of being carbon-free by midcentury, even as demands for energy rise, legislators are looking to satisfy both needs through a strategy many so far have tried to avoid: allowing new, large-scale nuclear reactors to be built in the state.

The initiative wending through the General Assembly comes even though Gov. JB Pritzker vetoed and narrowed a similar plan two years ago when he set limits on the size of new nuclear power plants in Illinois. But the governor appeared open to taking a different tack when he said recently he's willing to work with the bipartisan group of lawmakers backing the latest proposal that would

permit the construction of nuclear reactors of any size.

"We're looking forward to having a bill that comes to my desk that will allow us to expand the options for nuclear in the state of Illinois," Pritzker said last week. "But it has to be done in the right way, and I think the legislature and my team are working together to make sure that that happens."

Illinois has more nuclear reac-

tors than any other state. But supporters of allowing new, large reactors to be constructed in Illinois, including labor and manufacturing advocates, argue that building more nuclear power plants is needed to help answer rising energy demands and the state's ambitious clean energy goals, which call for retiring major traditional sources of power such as natural gas-fired energy plants by 2045.

The issue of broadly expanding nuclear power has historically

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Nabi Yisrael says he was turned away by the Salvation Army in January for lack of cots and got a similar response when he later called 311 in search of accessible space. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Disabled Chicagoans struggle to find space in homeless shelters

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

When Nabi Yisrael left his Hyde Park apartment last year after his rent increased, he had to put most of his belongings into storage. The 51-year-old, who has multiple sclerosis and uses a power wheelchair to get around, didn't have a home anymore.

For nearly six months since then, Yisrael bounced around

between his friends and families' apartments, carrying the necessities in a travel case — two pairs of jeans, a few pairs of shoes and five shirts, he said. For someone who prides himself on his fashion sense, it was a difficult transition.

"I've been wearing the same clothes since October," Yisrael said in a recent interview. "Since October."

About three months into essentially being homeless — for

the first time in his life — Yisrael came to another difficult conclusion. Despite the "horror stories" he heard from friends about the conditions inside Chicago's homeless shelters, particularly for people with disabilities, he decided he had no other choice but to seek placement at one. He needed a place to stay, and he needed it quickly, he said.

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For Trump, governing conducted by instinct

Some say decisions lack usual methods of deliberation

By Chris Megerian
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — After President Donald Trump reversed course on his tariffs and announced that he would pursue trade negotiations, he had a simple explanation for how he would make decisions in the coming weeks.

"Instinctively, more than anything else," he told reporters this past week. "You almost can't take a pencil to paper, it's really more of an instinct than anything else."

It was the latest example of how Trump loves to keep everyone on edge for his next move. Trump has not only expansively flexed the powers of the presidency by declaring emergencies and shredding political norms, he has eschewed traditional deliberative procedures for making decisions. The result is that more of life around the country and the world is subject to the president's desires, moods and grievances than ever before.

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